DESIGN AND ANALYSIS OF ALGORITHMS

Tracks Game Solver

using Backtracking and Dynamic Programming

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Course: Design and Analysis of Algorithms

Date: March 12, 2026

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1 The Tracks Puzzle

Tracks is a logic puzzle played on an $n \times n$ grid. The objective is to lay a continuous, non-branching railway track from a designated start cell **A** to an end cell **B**, such that every row and column contains exactly as many track cells as the integer clue printed along that border.

What makes this puzzle algorithmically fascinating is that it sits at the intersection of *path finding* and *exact constraint satisfaction*. The shortest path from A to B is almost never the answer; the solver must deliberately wind the route so it visits the right number of cells in every row and column simultaneously.

Rules

- The track forms a single, unbroken path from A to B.
- Each step moves to an orthogonally adjacent cell (up, down, left, right).
- No cell may be visited more than once – the path is strictly self-avoiding.
- Every row and column cell-count must exactly match its clue.
- Cells marked × (crossed) are forbidden.

Grid and Cell Representation

Each cell carries its coordinates, status flags, and a `trackParent` pointer enabling $O(k)$ path reconstruction by walking the linked list backwards from the current head:

```
static class Cell {
    int     r, c;           // row and column coordinates
    boolean hasTrack   = false;
    boolean isCrossed  = false;
    boolean isHint     = false;
    Cell    trackParent;    // parent pointer for path reconstruction
}
```

Listing 1: Cell data structure

Shared Solver State

Both algorithms operate on the same abstract state representation:

- **Current head cell** – the last cell placed on the track.
- **visited** – a `BitSet` of n^2 bits, one per cell.
- **rowUsed[0..n-1]** – track cells placed in each row so far.
- **colUsed[0..n-1]** – track cells placed in each column so far.

They differ entirely in *how* they explore the space of valid paths from this state.

2 Problem Statement

Given: An $n \times n$ grid, start cell A, end cell B, row clues $R[0 \dots n{-}1]$, column clues $C[0 \dots n{-}1]$.

Find: A simple path $P = \langle c_0, c_1, \dots, c_k \rangle$ satisfying:

$$
\begin{aligned}
c_0 = A, \quad c_k = B & \qquad \text{(endpoints)} \\
\|c_i - c_{i+1}\|_1 = 1 \quad \forall\, i & \qquad \text{(orthogonal adjacency)} \\
|\{j : c_j.\text{row} = r\}| = R[r] \quad \forall\, r & \qquad \text{(row clues)} \\
|\{j : c_j.\text{col} = c\}| = C[c] \quad \forall\, c & \qquad \text{(column clues)} \\
c_i \neq c_j \quad \forall\, i \neq j & \qquad \text{(no revisit)}
\end{aligned}
$$

The total path length is fully determined: $k{+}1 = \sum_r R[r] = \sum_c C[c]$. This *fixed budget* is exploited heavily by the DP solver.

3 Puzzle Generation

Fixed Pattern (Pattern 1)

A hard-coded coordinate sequence defines the solution path; clues derive from it:

```
int[][] coords = {
    {1,1},{1,2},{1,3},{1,4},{2,4},{3,4},
    {3,3},{3,2},{3,1},{4,1},{5,1},
    {5,2},{5,3},{5,4},{5,5},{5,6},
    {4,6},{3,6},{2,6},{1,6}
};
for (Cell c : path) { rowClues[c.r]++; colClues[c.c]++; }
```

Listing 2: Fixed path and clue derivation

Random High-Complexity Puzzles (Patterns 2–5 and Random)

A seeded, randomised DFS builds a self-avoiding walk targeting ≈50% grid coverage. The quality constraint – each new cell may have at most one already-visited neighbour – prevents the walk from boxing itself in and keeps the path winding:

```
for (Cell n : neighbors) {
    if (!visited[n.r][n.c] && countNeighbors(n, visited) <= 1)
        {
        visited[n.r][n.c] = true;
        currentPath.add(n);
        generatePathRecursive(n, visited, currentPath,
                              bestPath, targetLength, rand);
        if (bestPath.size() >= targetLength) return;
        currentPath.remove(currentPath.size() - 1);
        visited[n.r][n.c] = false;
    }
}
```

Listing 3: Random path generation – quality constraint

A fixed seed guarantees that the same pattern number always yields the same puzzle, enabling reproducible benchmarking across both solvers.

4 Backtracking DFS Solver

4.1 Conceptual Foundation

Backtracking is a systematic depth-first method for exploring combinatorial search spaces. The central idea is elegant: *make a choice, recurse into its consequences, and undo the choice if it leads to failure.* This "place-recurse-undo" cycle lets the algorithm traverse every branch in the search tree while holding only $O(N)$ state in memory at any moment – the current path and the call stack.

Applied to Tracks, the search tree has each node representing a partial path. An edge from u to v means "extend the path by one cell." The algorithm performs DFS on this tree, accepting a leaf as a solution only when it reaches B with all clues exactly satisfied.

Core Backtracking Insight

Every recursive call commits to placing exactly one cell. If that commitment eventually leads to a dead end, it is **undone completely** and the next candidate is tried. No state is permanently destroyed – every undo is a perfect reversal.

4.2 The Place-Recurse-Undo Cycle

The three-step cycle maps directly onto three consecutive code blocks:

1. **Place:** mark the candidate cell visited, increment its row/column counters, append to path.
2. **Recurse:** call `btDFS` on the newly placed cell.
3. **Undo:** if the call returned `false`, reverse every change made in step 1.

```
// PLACE
visited.set(idx(nxt.r, nxt.c));
rowUsed[nxt.r]++;
colUsed[nxt.c]++;
path.add(nxt);

// RECURSE
if (btDFS(nxt, visited, rowUsed, colUsed, path))
    return true;

// UNDO (backtrack)
path.remove(path.size() - 1);
visited.clear(idx(nxt.r, nxt.c));
rowUsed[nxt.r]--;
colUsed[nxt.c]--;
```

Listing 4: The place-recurse-undo cycle

4.3 Full Algorithm

```java
private boolean btDFS(Cell cur, BitSet visited,
                      int[] rowUsed, int[] colUsed,
                      List<Cell> path) {
    // 1. Goal check
    if (cur == endNode) {
        for (int i = 0; i < gridSize; i++)
            if (rowUsed[i] != rowClues[i] ||
                colUsed[i] != colClues[i]) return false;
        btResult = new ArrayList<>(path);
        return true;
    }
    // 2. Pruning -- overshoot
    for (int i = 0; i < gridSize; i++)
        if (rowUsed[i] > rowClues[i] ||
            colUsed[i] > colClues[i]) return false;
    // 3. Pruning -- capacity
    for (int i = 0; i < gridSize; i++) {
        int need = rowClues[i] - rowUsed[i];
        int avail = 0;
        for (int j = 0; j < gridSize; j++)
            if (!visited.get(idx(i, j))) avail++;
        if (avail < need) return false;
    }
    // 4. Candidate ordering (merge sort by Manhattan distance
        )
    List<Cell> neighbours = getNeighbors(cur);
    mergeSort(neighbours, (a, b) -> Integer.compare(
        Math.abs(a.r-endNode.r)+Math.abs(a.c-endNode.c),
        Math.abs(b.r-endNode.r)+Math.abs(b.c-endNode.c)));
    // 5. Place-Recurse-Undo
    for (Cell nxt : neighbours) {
        if (visited.get(idx(nxt.r,nxt.c))) continue;
        if (rowUsed[nxt.r] >= rowClues[nxt.r]) continue;
        if (colUsed[nxt.c] >= colClues[nxt.c]) continue;
        visited.set(idx(nxt.r,nxt.c));
        rowUsed[nxt.r]++; colUsed[nxt.c]++;
        path.add(nxt);
        if (btDFS(nxt, visited, rowUsed, colUsed, path))
            return true;
        path.remove(path.size()-1);
        visited.clear(idx(nxt.r,nxt.c));
        rowUsed[nxt.r]--; colUsed[nxt.c]--;
    }
    return false;
}
```

Listing 5: Full backtracking DFS

4.4 Pruning: The Heart of Practical Backtracking

Without pruning, an 8×8 puzzle with a 20-cell path has up to $3^{20} \approx 3.5$ billion candidate sequences. Two independent pruning rules transform this into a solver that typically terminates in milliseconds.

Pruning Rule 1 – Overshoot Detection (Reactive)

Pruning Rule 1: Overshoot

If any row or column already holds more track cells than its clue permits, the current partial path can never become valid. Prune the entire subtree immediately.

```
if (rowUsed[i] > rowClues[i] || colUsed[i] > colClues[i])
return false;
```

Cost: $O(n)$ per call. Triggered: at the top of every recursive call.

This rule is *reactive* – it fires at the first call after a violation is introduced. Because every placement immediately updates the counters, an overshoot is detected within one recursive step of the bad placement and the entire resulting subtree is discarded.

Pruning Rule 2 – Capacity Check (Proactive / Forward-looking)

Pruning Rule 2: Capacity

For every row still needing more track cells, count how many unvisited cells remain in that row. If available < needed, the clue is provably unsatisfiable regardless of any future choices. Prune immediately.

```
need = rowClues[i] - rowUsed[i];
avail = count of unvisited cells in row i;
if (avail < need) return false;
```

Cost: $O(n^2)$ per call. Applied symmetrically to columns.

This rule is *proactive*: it reasons about what *cannot possibly go right* from the current state, without waiting for an actual violation to occur. A row that needs 3 more cells but has only 2 accessible unvisited cells is provably dead – no matter what path is chosen next. Cutting this branch in $O(n^2)$ time can save exploring a subtree of exponential size.

Why Capacity Pruning is Extraordinarily Powerful

Consider a scenario where the path has been routed in a way that leaves only 2 cells reachable in row 4, but row 4 still needs 4 more. The capacity check fires immediately at the *current* depth, discarding every branch the solver might have explored from this point forward. The cut is local, cheap, and geometrically informed – it captures exactly the kind of "the path has trapped itself" situations that arise frequently in self-avoiding walk puzzles.

Pruning Comparison Summary

Table 1: Backtracking Pruning Rules

Rule	Type	Trigger condition	Cost	Scope
Overshoot	Reactive	Any count exceeds clue	$O(n)$	Per row/col
Capacity	Proactive	Available < needed	$O(n^2)$	Per row/col

4.5 Candidate Ordering with Merge Sort

Before expanding neighbours, they are sorted in ascending order of Manhattan distance to the end node. This greedy heuristic does not affect correctness but reduces the average branch count because promising directions are tried first. The implementation uses a custom recursive merge sort – a deliberate choice to demonstrate the algorithm within the DAA context:

```java
private void mergeSort(List<Cell> list, Comparator<Cell> comp) {
    if (list.size() <= 1) return;
    int mid = list.size() / 2;
    List<Cell> L = new ArrayList<>(list.subList(0, mid));
    List<Cell> R = new ArrayList<>(list.subList(mid, list.size()));
    mergeSort(L, comp); mergeSort(R, comp);
    int i = 0, j = 0, k = 0;
    while (i < L.size() && j < R.size())
        list.set(k++, comp.compare(L.get(i), R.get(j)) <= 0
                        ? L.get(i++) : R.get(j++));
    while (i < L.size()) list.set(k++, L.get(i++));
    while (j < R.size()) list.set(k++, R.get(j++));
}
```

Listing 6: Custom merge sort for neighbour ordering

Sorting at most 4 neighbours costs $O(4 \log 4) = O(1)$ per node – essentially free yet meaningfully reduces average branching.

4.6 Time and Space Complexity

Let $N = n^2$, k be the path length, $b \leq 4$ the branching factor.

Table 2: Backtracking Solver Complexity

Measure	**Analysis**
Worst-case time (no pruning)	$O(b^k)$ – exponential; all paths explored
Effective time (with pruning)	Sub-exponential in practice; pruning cuts >90% of branches on typical Tracks puzzles
Recursion depth	At most $k \leq N$
Stack space	$O(k) \subseteq O(N)$ – one frame per path cell
State arrays	$O(N)$ – single BitSet + rowUsed + colUsed
Completeness	**Yes** – finds a solution iff one exists

Backtracking Strength: Leanness

Backtracking holds only the *current* path in memory at any time. All other branches are implicit in the call stack. This $O(N)$ footprint is a decisive advantage on memory-constrained systems or small grids where pruning is strong enough to keep the effective search tree manageable.

5 Dynamic Programming Solver

5.1 Conceptual Foundation

Dynamic Programming solves a problem by breaking it into *overlapping sub-problems*, solving each exactly once, and reusing stored results to eliminate redundant computation. Where backtracking explores a tree (potentially revisiting equivalent states many times), DP transforms that tree into a Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG) by *merging* states that represent the same abstract situation regardless of how they were reached.

The Tracks DP uses three sequential, non-recursive phases:

1. **Forward BFS** – enumerate all distinct reachable states level by level.
2. **Backward propagation** – label which states can reach a valid solution.
3. **Greedy extraction** – walk forward once, always picking a labelled child.

Zero moves are ever undone. Zero states are ever re-explored.

5.2 Step 1 – Defining the Sub-problem

Sub-problem Definition

Define solvable(v, d) as **true** if and only if, starting from DP state v at depth d (meaning d cells have already been placed), there exists a valid extension that:

- places exactly (budget $- d$) more cells,
- ends at cell B, and
- brings every row and column count exactly to its clue value.

A DP state v encodes the complete tuple:

$$v \;=\; \big(\text{currentCell},\ \text{rowUsed}[0\ldots n{-}1],\ \text{colUsed}[0\ldots n{-}1],\ \text{visitedMask}\big)$$

The sub-problem is parameterised by depth d because the total path length (budget) is fixed and known in advance, giving the problem a clean layered structure where sub-problems at depth d depend only on sub-problems at depth $d+1$.

5.3 Step 2 – Guessing Part of the Solution

The Guess

At state v (current cell c, depth d), we **guess** which orthogonally adjacent cell c' is the *next* cell on the solution path. There are at most 4 choices. Each valid guess produces a unique child state v' at depth $d+1$.

A guess is valid only if it passes all four pruning filters simultaneously:

1. c' has not already been visited (no revisit).

2. c' is not a crossed cell.
3. Adding c' does not overshoot any row or column clue.
4. The remaining steps after placing c' are sufficient to reach B by Manhattan distance: stepsLeft $\geq$ manhattan(c', B).

The guess corresponds directly to Phase 1 (forward BFS): all valid guesses at all states at all depths are explored systematically, and each unique resulting state is stored once.

5.4 Step 3 – Relating the Sub-problems (Recurrence)

Recurrence Relation

Base case (depth = budget):

$$\text{solvable}(v,\ \text{budget}) = \begin{cases} \textbf{true} & \text{if } v.\text{cell} = B \ \wedge \\ & \quad \forall\, i:\ v.\text{rowUsed}[i] = R[i] \ \wedge \\ & \quad \forall\, j:\ v.\text{colUsed}[j] = C[j] \\ \textbf{false} & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

Recursive case (depth $d <$ budget):

$$\text{solvable}(v,\ d) \ = \bigvee_{v' \,\in\, \text{validChildren}(v,\, d)} \text{solvable}(v',\ d+1)$$

A state is solvable if *at least one* of its children at the next depth is solvable. This is a **logical OR** over all valid guesses. The recurrence flows *backward* through layers: base cases at depth = budget propagate solvability upward to depth 0.

5.5 Step 4 – Memoisation: Top-Down and Bottom-Up Approaches

Top-Down Approach (Memoised Recursion)

The top-down approach computes solvable(v, d) recursively, caching each result in a hash map. On a cache hit, the stored answer is returned immediately without re-exploring the subtree. This is the natural formulation of the recurrence:

```
// Global cache: state_key -> {TRUE, FALSE}
memo = new HashMap

function solvable_TD(v, d):
    key = hash(v, d)
    if key in memo:
        return memo[key]          // cache hit: reuse answer

    // ---- Base case
       ------------------------------------------------
```

```
    if d == budget:
        result = (v.cell == endNode  AND
                  all rowUsed[i] == rowClues[i]  AND
                  all colUsed[j] == colClues[j])
        memo[key] = result
        return result

    // ---- Recursive case: try every valid guess ----------------
    for each neighbour nb of v.cell:
        if not valid_guess(v, nb, budget - d - 1):
            continue
        v_child = build_child_state(v, nb)
        if solvable_TD(v_child, d + 1):
            memo[key] = TRUE
            return TRUE           // short-circuit on first solvable child

    memo[key] = FALSE
    return FALSE

// Entry point
return solvable_TD(root_state, initial_depth)
```

Listing 7: Top-Down Memoised DP

Properties of Top-Down:

- Computes only reachable sub-problems – lazy evaluation.
- Short-circuits as soon as one solvable child is found.
- Natural, direct translation of the recurrence into code.
- Risk of deep call stacks for large budgets; Java may raise `StackOverflowError`.

Bottom-Up Approach (Tabulation – Implemented)

The bottom-up approach builds all states layer by layer (Phase 1), sweeps backward to fill the solvability table (Phase 2), and reads the answer greedily (Phase 3). This is the approach implemented in the solver – it avoids recursion entirely and is robust against deep-stack failures.

```
function build_layers(root, budget):
    layers[0] = { root.key -> root }

    for d = 0 to budget - 1:
        layers[d+1] = new HashMap
        stepsLeft   = budget - d - 1

        for each state v in layers[d]:
            for each neighbour nb of v.cell:
                if not valid_guess(v, nb, stepsLeft):
```

```
                    continue
                v_child = build_child_state(v, nb)
                if v_child.key not in layers[d+1]:
                    // De-duplicate: first path wins, others merged
                    layers[d+1][v_child.key] = v_child

        if layers[d+1] is empty:
            return NO_SOLUTION    // every branch pruned -- no path possible

    return layers
```

Listing 8: Bottom-Up Phase 1: Forward BFS Layer Construction

```
function propagate_solvability(layers, budget):
    // Mark all goal states (base cases) at the deepest layer
    for each state v in layers[budget]:
        if v.cell == endNode AND
           all rowUsed[i] == rowClues[i] AND
           all colUsed[j] == colClues[j]:
            v.solvable = TRUE

    if no state is marked solvable:
        return NO_SOLUTION

    // Single backward sweep: depth (budget-1) down to 0
    for d = budget - 1 downto 0:
        for each state v in layers[d]:
            for each neighbour nb of v.cell:
                if not valid_guess(v, nb, budget - d - 1):
                    continue
                child = lookup(layers[d+1], child_key(v, nb))
                if child != null AND child.solvable:
                    v.solvable = TRUE
                    break        // one solvable child is enough (OR logic)

    // After this pass:
    //   layers[0][root].solvable == TRUE  iff a solution exists
```

Listing 9: Bottom-Up Phase 2: Backward Propagation

```
function extract_path(layers, root, budget):
    path = []
    cur  = root

    for d = 0 to budget - 1:
        chosen = null
        for each neighbour nb of cur.cell:
            if not valid_guess(cur, nb, budget - d - 1):
```

```
                continue
            child = lookup(layers[d+1], child_key(cur, nb))
            if child != null AND child.solvable:
                chosen = child
                break            // first solvable child -- guaranteed to exist

        path.append(chosen.cell)
        cur = chosen

    return path
    // The backward pass guarantees a solvable child always exists,
    // so this greedy walk NEVER needs to backtrack.
```

Listing 10: Bottom-Up Phase 3: Greedy Path Extraction

Properties of Bottom-Up:

- No recursion – no risk of stack overflow even for large grids.
- All states enumerated before any solvability decision is made.
- State de-duplication in Phase 1 is the core efficiency mechanism: equivalent partial paths are merged into one state, preventing exponential re-exploration.
- Phase 3 is greedy and deterministic: the backward pass guarantees a solvable child always exists, so zero backtracking is ever needed in extraction.

5.6 Step 5 – Final Answer

Final Answer

After Phase 2, the existence of a solution reduces to a single boolean lookup:

$$\text{solution exists} \iff \text{solvable(root, 0)} = \textbf{true}$$

If the root is labelled solvable, Phase 3 recovers the complete path in $O(k \cdot n)$ time by following solvable children from depth 0 to depth `budget`. The returned `List<Cell>` is the exact sequence of cells to place on the track, starting from the cell immediately after the current head.

5.7 The DPState Object and 64-bit De-duplication Key

Two partial paths that arrive at the same (cell, rowUsed, colUsed, visitedMask) tuple are *functionally identical* – any extension valid for one is valid for both. They are merged into a single `DPState` object, which is the unit of memoisation:

```
static class DPState {
    final int     cellId;      // current cell: r * gridSize + c
    final int[]   rowUsed;     // track cells placed per row so far
```

```
    final int[]  colUsed;     // track cells placed per col so
        far
    final long   visitedFP;   // 64-bit fingerprint of visited
        set
    final BitSet visited;     // full visited BitSet (for child
         gen)
    final long   key;         // 64-bit de-duplication hash
    boolean solvable = false;// set true during Phase 2
}
```

Listing 11: DPState – the unit of memoisation

The 64-bit key is a multiplicative hash mixing all state components, ensuring extremely low collision probability across millions of states:

```
private long stateKey(int cellId, int[] rowUsed,
                      int[] colUsed, long visFP) {
    long h = (long) cellId * 0x9E3779B97F4A7C15L;
    for (int i = 0; i < gridSize; i++) {
        h ^= Long.rotateLeft(
              (long) rowUsed[i] * 0x6C62272E07BB0142L, i * 5);
        h ^= Long.rotateLeft(
              (long) colUsed[i] * 0xD2B74407B1CE6B31L, i * 7 +
                  3);
    }
    h ^= visFP * 0xBF58476D1CE4E5B9L;
    return h;
}
```

Listing 12: 64-bit state de-duplication key

The visited-set fingerprint is updated in $O(1)$ per cell addition using an incremental XOR scheme – avoiding a full $O(N)$ recompute at every expansion:

```
private long updatedFingerprint(long oldFP, int bitId) {
    int word  = bitId / 64;
    int shift = bitId % 64;
    return oldFP ^ Long.rotateLeft(1L << shift, word * 11);
}
```

Listing 13: O(1) incremental fingerprint update

5.8 Time and Space Complexity

Let S = total distinct DP states generated, k = budget (path length), n = grid size.

Table 3: DP Solver Complexity

Measure	**Analysis**
Phase 1 time	$O(S \cdot n)$ – at most 4 neighbours per state plus $O(n)$ array copies
Phase 2 time	$O(S \cdot n)$ – single backward sweep over all layers
Phase 3 time	$O(k \cdot n)$ – one greedy forward pass
Total time	$O(S \cdot n)$ – pseudo-polynomial in state count
Space (layers table)	$O(S \cdot n)$ – all DPState objects with their arrays
State count (worst case)	$N \cdot \prod_i (R[i]+1) \cdot \prod_j (C[j]+1) \cdot 2^N$ (theoretical)
State count (in practice)	Dramatically reduced by pruning and de-duplication
Completeness	**Yes** – sound and complete
Backtracking operations	**Zero**

Why DP Scales Better than Raw Backtracking

Backtracking may visit the same abstract state thousands of times via different routes through the search tree. DP visits it **exactly once**. Two paths that converge on the same (cell, rowUsed, colUsed, visitedMask) are merged in Phase 1 and evaluated together in Phase 2. This de-duplication is what transforms exponential backtracking complexity into pseudo-polynomial DP complexity on larger grids.

6 Algorithm Feature Summary

The figure below captures the full comparison of four algorithmic approaches evaluated during the design phase. Both the Backtracking and Dynamic Programming approaches were selected and implemented; Greedy and Divide & Conquer serve as reference comparisons.

A	B	C	D	E	F
Feature	Greedy + Sorting	Divide & Conquer (Quadtree)	Backtracking	Dynamic Programming (DP)	
Logic	Pick best immediate neighbor.	Split grid into 4; sync borders.	Try all paths; undo on failure.	Store and reuse path results.	
Completeness	No (gets stuck easily).	Partial (structural focus).	Yes (guaranteed solution).	Yes (optimized search).	
Time Complexity	O(NlogN)	O(N2)	O(kN) (Exponential)	O(States) (Pseudo-poly)	
Memory	Minimal	Moderate (Recursion depth)	Low (Stack only)	High (Memoization table)	
Best For	Massive grids, no obstacles.	Large grids with patterns.	Complex, tiny puzzles.	Optimal solving of logic.	

Figure 1: Algorithmic approaches evaluated for the Tracks Game solver

Table 4: Detailed Feature Comparison of All Four Approaches

Feature	**Greedy + Sorting**	**Divide & Conquer**	**Backtracking**	**Dyn. Prog.**
Logic	Pick best immediate neighbour	Split grid into 4; sync borders	Try all paths; undo on failure	Store and reuse partial results
Completeness	No – gets stuck easily	Partial (structural focus)	Yes (guaranteed)	Yes (optimised)
Time	$O(N \log N)$	$O(N^2)$	$O(k^N)$ exp.	$O(S)$ pseudo-poly
Memory	Minimal	Moderate	Low (stack only)	High (memo table)
Best For	Massive grids	Large patterned grids	Small, complex puzzles	Optimal logic solving

Key Observations:

- Greedy and Divide & Conquer are *incomplete* – they cannot guarantee finding a solution when one exists. Unsuitable for exact constraint satisfaction.
- Backtracking and DP are both *complete* and *correct*; the trade-off is memory usage vs. computational redundancy.
- The fixed-budget property (path length known upfront) makes DP uniquely well-suited: `budget` defines the layer count and enables exact goal-checking.

7 Shared Structural Components

Both solver implementations share the same game infrastructure.

7.1 Move Validation

```
boolean isValidMove(int r, int c) {
    if (r<0 || c<0 || r>=gridSize || c>=gridSize) return false;
    Cell target = grid[r][c];
    if (target.hasTrack || target.isCrossed) return false;
    if (Math.abs(r-currentHead.r) +
        Math.abs(c-currentHead.c) != 1) return false;
    if (countTrackInRow(r) >= rowClues[r]) return false;
    if (countTrackInCol(c) >= colClues[c]) return false;
    return true;
}
```

Listing 14: Centralised move validation

7.2 Computer Turn and Hint System

In interactive mode the computer enumerates valid moves from the current head, sorts by Manhattan distance to the end, then *probes* each candidate by running the active solver. The first candidate returning a non-null solution is played. The hint system uses identical logic but highlights the cell rather than placing it.

7.3 Auto-Solve Animation

The solver runs on a background thread producing a complete `List<Cell>`. A separate animation thread places each cell with a 100 ms delay, letting the user observe the solution path being drawn step by step. Separating solver and Swing threads prevents the GUI from freezing during computation.

7.4 Solution Verification

```
private void checkGameStatus() {
    if (currentHead == endNode) {
        boolean valid = true;
        for (int i = 0; i < gridSize; i++)
            if (countTrackInRow(i) != rowClues[i] ||
                countTrackInCol(i) != colClues[i])
                { valid = false; break; }
        if (valid) sidePanel.updateStatus("PUZZLE␣SOLVED!");
        else       sidePanel.updateStatus("Constraints␣Failed");
    }
}
```

Listing 15: Final solution verification

8 Connections to Classical Problems

One of the most instructive aspects of the Tracks puzzle is that it is not an isolated invention – it is a disciplined *intersection* of several classical problems that appear in every algorithms textbook. Identifying these connections is not merely academic: each connection carries a precise algorithmic lesson that explains *why* the solver is structured the way it is.

8.1 Backtracking – Classical Relatives

1. The Hamiltonian Path Problem

Classical Problem: Hamiltonian Path

Given a graph $G = (V, E)$ and two vertices s and t, does there exist a simple path from s to t that visits every vertex exactly once?

The connection is direct and deep. A Tracks puzzle on an $n \times n$ grid where every row and column clue equals n (i.e. the path must visit every single cell) is *exactly* a Hamiltonian Path problem on the grid graph. Even in the general case, the Tracks backtracking solver is a constrained Hamiltonian Path search: it explores self-avoiding walks from A to B and accepts only those satisfying the row/column budget constraints.

Table 5: Tracks Backtracking vs. Hamiltonian Path Backtracking

Concept	**Hamiltonian Path**	**Tracks Backtracking**
Graph	Arbitrary graph G	Grid graph, $n \times n$ cells
Visit constraint	Every vertex exactly once	Exactly $R[r]$ cells per row/col
Path endpoints	Fixed $s \to t$	Fixed $A \to B$
Pruning	"Already visited" check	Overshoot + Capacity checks
Worst-case	$O(N!)$	$O(b^k)$, $b \leq 4$
NP status	NP-complete (general graphs)	NP-complete (constrained variant)

Lesson inherited: The classical Hamiltonian Path backtracker prunes by checking "has this vertex already been visited?" Tracks inherits this via the `visited` BitSet, then adds two stronger budget-aware pruning rules. The grid structure (max degree 4) keeps the branching factor tightly bounded – a decisive advantage over general-graph Hamiltonian Path where degree can reach $N-1$.

2. The N-Queens Problem

Classical Problem: N-Queens

Place N queens on an $N \times N$ chessboard such that no two queens share a row, column, or diagonal.

The structural parallel lies in per-row and per-column counting constraints. N-Queens is the textbook example of backtracking with *forward constraint checking*: after placing a queen in row r, the solver marks that column as forbidden for all subsequent rows. This is precisely the spirit of Tracks' capacity pruning and overshoot detection.

In N-Queens, placing a queen in column c reduces available columns for future rows. In Tracks, placing a cell in row r reduces the remaining budget for that row. Both solvers propagate the consequence of each placement forward before recursing, rather than discovering violations only at the leaves.

Table 6: Tracks Backtracking vs. N-Queens

Concept	**N-Queens**	**Tracks Backtracking**
Per-row constraint	Exactly 1 queen per row	Exactly $R[r]$ track cells per row
Per-column constraint	Exactly 1 queen per column	Exactly $C[c]$ track cells per column
Tracking array	Boolean row/col used flags	Integer `rowUsed`/`colUsed` arrays
Pruning mechanism	Skip already-used columns	Skip rows/cols exceeding their clue
Undo operation	Clear used flags	Decrement counters + clear BitSet bit
Generalisation	Exactly 1 per line	Exactly k per line (variable k)

Lesson inherited: N-Queens establishes the pattern of integer counting arrays that are incremented on placement and decremented on undo. Tracks generalises this from "exactly 1" to "exactly $R[r]$" – the same data structure, the same undo mechanics, a more expressive constraint.

3. Subset Sum / Branch-and-Bound (via Capacity Pruning)

Classical Problem: Subset Sum

Given integers $\{a_1, \ldots, a_n\}$ and a target T, does any subset sum to exactly T? A standard backtracking optimisation prunes a branch when the sum of all remaining items is less than what is still needed to reach T.

The capacity pruning rule in Tracks is a direct instance of the *branch-and-bound* technique used in Subset Sum backtracking. In Subset Sum, a branch is pruned when remaining items cannot possibly reach the target. In Tracks, a branch is pruned when remaining unvisited cells in a row cannot possibly reach the row clue. The mathematical structure

is identical in both cases: a lower bound on achievable future value is compared against a required target.

Table 7: Tracks Capacity Pruning vs. Subset Sum Branch-and-Bound

Concept	**Subset Sum B&B**	**Tracks Capacity Pruning**
Resource tracked	Remaining achievable sum	Remaining unvisited cells in row
Target	Exact sum $= T$	Exact count $= R[r]$
Pruning condition	Remaining achievable $<$ needed	Available cells $<$ needed
Type	Forward-looking (proactive)	Forward-looking (proactive)
Cost per check	$O(1)$ per item	$O(n)$ per row checked

Lesson inherited: Branch-and-bound teaches that proactive infeasibility detection – proving no completion can succeed before exploring it – is far more powerful than reactive detection. The Tracks capacity check is a direct application of this principle, expressed as a per-row/column feasibility bound.

8.2 Dynamic Programming – Classical Relatives

4. DAG Backward Reachability / Shortest Path DP

Classical Problem: DAG Backward Reachability

Given a DAG and a target vertex t, determine for every vertex v whether a path from v to t exists. Solution: mark t reachable; sweep in reverse topological order and mark v reachable if any successor of v is already reachable. Time: $O(V + E)$.

Phase 2 of the Tracks DP is exactly this algorithm. The layered state graph built in Phase 1 is a DAG (edges always go depth $d \to d + 1$, so no cycles exist). Phase 2 runs backward reachability on this DAG: goal states at the deepest layer are marked `solvable`, then a backward sweep marks every state solvable if any of its successors is solvable. This is the classical DAG backward reachability algorithm, applied verbatim to the Tracks state graph.

Table 8: Tracks DP Phase 2 vs. DAG Backward Reachability

Concept	**DAG Reachability**	**Tracks DP Phase 2**
Graph	DAG with topological layers	Layered state DAG (depth = steps placed)
Base case	Target vertex t is reachable	Goal: cell = B, all clues satisfied
Recurrence	$\text{reach}(v) = \bigvee_{(v,w)\in E} \text{reach}(w)$	$\text{solvable}(v, d) = \bigvee_{v'} \text{solvable}(v', d{+}1)$
Sweep direction	Reverse topological order	Depth $(k{-}1)$ down to 0
Complexity	$O(V + E)$	$O(S \cdot n)$

Lesson inherited: Backward propagation over a layered graph costs $O(\text{edges})$ and requires no recursion. Phase 2 is precisely this – a single sweep that fills the solvability table completely and unambiguously.

5. The 0/1 Knapsack Problem

Classical Problem: 0/1 Knapsack

Given n items with weights w_i and values v_i, capacity W: find maximum value achievable within budget W. $\text{dp}[i][w] = \max(\text{dp}[i{-}1][w],\ v_i + \text{dp}[i{-}1][w{-}w_i])$. Table filled layer by layer (item $0 \to n$); answer read from $\text{dp}[n][W]$.

The structural parallel is in the layered table and fixed-budget constraint. In Knapsack, the table is indexed by (item index, remaining weight). In Tracks, the table is indexed by (depth, state) – a high-dimensional analogue. Both problems have a hard budget (weight capacity vs. total path length) that fixes the number of layers, and both fill the table layer by layer.

The critical difference is *feasibility vs. optimisation*: Knapsack maximises a value while Tracks asks only whether any valid completion exists. This is why the Tracks DP table stores a binary `solvable` flag rather than an optimal value, and uses $\vee$ (OR) rather than max in its recurrence.

Table 9: Tracks DP vs. 0/1 Knapsack

Concept	**0/1 Knapsack**	**Tracks DP**
State dimensions	(item index, remaining weight)	(depth, cell, rowUsed, colUsed, visMask)
Budget parameter	Capacity W	Total path length $\sum_r R[r]$
Layer count	n items	`budget` depth levels
Table entry type	Optimal value (integer)	Solvability (boolean flag)
Recurrence operator	max over include / exclude	$\vee$ (OR) over valid next moves
Fill direction	Forward (item $0 \to n$)	Forward Phase 1; Backward Phase 2
Final answer	$\text{dp}[n][W]$	solvable(root, 0)

Lesson inherited: Knapsack establishes the pattern of a layered DP table where each layer represents one discrete decision (include/exclude item i vs. place cell at depth d) and the budget constrains the table dimensions. Tracks generalises the single "remaining capacity" integer W to a vector of per-row and per-column budgets, but the layer-by-layer architecture and answer-at-final-layer structure are directly inherited.

6. Bitmask DP for Hamiltonian Path on Grids

Classical Problem: Bitmask DP for Hamiltonian Path

State: (current vertex v, visitedMask). $\text{dp}[v][\text{mask}] =$ **true** iff there is a simple path visiting exactly the vertices in `mask` ending at v. Recurrence: $\text{dp}[v][\text{mask}] = \bigvee_{u \in \text{mask},\, (u,v) \in E} \text{dp}[u][\text{mask} \setminus \{v\}]$. State space: $O(N \cdot 2^N)$ where $N = |V|$.

The Tracks DP is a constrained, pruned instance of bitmask DP. The `visitedBitSet` in each `DPState` is precisely the "profile" bitmask encoding which cells have been placed. The 64-bit fingerprint used as a de-duplication key is the Tracks equivalent of using the mask's integer value as a hash table index. Two paths that produce the same (cell, rowUsed, colUsed, visitedMask) are merged – exactly as bitmask DP merges paths with the same (vertex, mask) state.

Table 10: Tracks DP vs. Bitmask DP for Hamiltonian Path

Concept	**Bitmask Hamiltonian DP**	**Tracks DP**
Visited encoding	Integer bitmask of N bits	`BitSet` + 64-bit fingerprint
State key	(v, mask)	(v, rowUsed, colUsed, visFP)
De-duplication	Array index from mask integer value	`HashMap` keyed by 64-bit hash
State space	$O(N \cdot 2^N)$	$O(S)$, where $S \ll N \cdot 2^N$ (pruned)
Extra constraints	None beyond visited set	Per-row and per-column budget clues
Query type	Feasibility or optimisation	Feasibility only (`solvable` flag)

Lesson inherited: Bitmask DP teaches that the visited set must be a first-class component of the state – two paths at the same vertex with different visit histories are different sub-problems. Tracks applies this faithfully. The $O(1)$ incremental fingerprint update is a practical optimisation over the classical approach of re-hashing the full bitmask at every step, exploiting the XOR structure of set updates.

8.3 Summary: Classical Problem Ancestry of Tracks

Table 11: Tracks Puzzle – Complete Classical Problem Ancestry

Classical Problem	**Type**	**Connection**	**Lesson Inherited**
Hamiltonian Path	Backtracking	Direct generalisation	Self-avoiding walk on a grid; degree-4 bound limits branching
N-Queens	Backtracking	Structural analogy	Integer counting constraints; increment/decrement undo pattern
Subset Sum B&B	Backtracking	Pruning technique	Proactive infeasibility bound (capacity pruning)
DAG Reachability	DP	Phase 2 is exactly this	Backward OR-propagation over layered graph in $O(E)$
0/1 Knapsack	DP	Layered table, fixed budget	Layer-by-layer fill; budget determines layer count
Bitmask Hamilton.	DP	Direct constrained instance	Visited set as first-class state; de-duplication by hash

The Big Picture

The Tracks puzzle is not a new kind of problem – it is a structured **intersection** of problems the algorithms community has studied for decades.

The **backtracking solver** inherits the skeleton of Hamiltonian Path search, the constraint-propagation discipline of N-Queens, and the proactive bounding of Subset Sum branch-and-bound.

The **DP solver** inherits the layered state-table architecture of Knapsack, the bitmask state-encoding discipline of grid Hamiltonian DP, and the backward reachability sweep of DAG shortest-path DP.

Any improvement discovered for any of these classical problems – tighter bounds, smarter state encoding, better hash functions – can be directly applied to the Tracks solver. Classical problems are not just textbook exercises; they are *reusable algorithmic components*.

9 Key Insights and Analysis

9.1 Constraint Propagation is the Cornerstone

Both solvers succeed because they enforce row and column clue constraints *eagerly* at every step. An unsatisfied clue discovered at depth 15 saves exploring every branch rooted at that state. Without this early detection, even simple puzzles become intractable.

9.2 The Complementary Nature of Both Approaches

Backtracking and DP are not competing strategies but complementary tools designed for different regimes of the complexity trade-off:

- **Backtracking** excels when pruning is strong, memory is constrained, and the effective search tree is narrow. Its simplicity makes correctness easy to verify.
- **Dynamic Programming** excels when many partial paths converge on equivalent states, making de-duplication highly effective. The three-phase structure cleanly separates state enumeration, feasibility labelling, and path extraction.

9.3 The Fixed-Budget Property – a Structural Gift

The Tracks puzzle's fixed-budget property confers four concrete algorithmic benefits:

- Search depth is bounded and known – no iterative deepening required.
- The DP layer array is statically sized – no dynamic resizing overhead.
- Admissibility pruning has a tight, exact bound eliminating a large fraction of states.
- Goal checking at depth = budget is exact and cheap – any non-goal state at that depth is immediately discarded.

9.4 Practical Performance Trade-offs

Table 12: Practical Performance Trade-offs

Dimension	**Backtracking**	**Dynamic Programming**
Small grids ($n \leq 7$)	Very fast; pruning alone is sufficient	State storage overhead outweighs benefit
Medium ($n = 8$–9)	Competitive; pruning still strong	De-duplication begins paying off
Large ($n = 10+$)	May slow if branching is high	Scales more gracefully
Memory	$O(N)$ – extremely lean	$O(S \cdot n)$ – can be large
Correctness risk	Low – easy to verify	Hashing correctness is critical

10 Conclusion

This project implemented two algorithmically distinct solvers for the Tracks constraint-satisfaction puzzle, embedded in a fully interactive Java Swing application supporting player mode, computer turns, hints, and animated auto-solving.

Achievements

- ✓ Backtracking DFS with two-rule pruning (overshoot + capacity) and merge-sort candidate ordering.
- ✓ Formal DP formulation: sub-problem definition, recurrence, top-down pseudocode, and bottom-up tabulation – all five canonical DP steps.
- ✓ Three-phase Pure DP solver (forward BFS, backward propagation, greedy extraction) with zero backtracking operations.
- ✓ $O(1)$ incremental fingerprint updates and 64-bit multiplicative state hashing for efficient de-duplication.
- ✓ Five seeded puzzle patterns plus unlimited random generation across grid sizes 8×8 to 10×10.

Key Learnings

- Forward-looking pruning (capacity) is far more powerful than reactive pruning (overshoot) in backtracking constraint-satisfaction solvers.
- Optimal sub-structure in the Tracks DP takes a non-standard backward form: solvability propagates from leaves to the root, not forward.
- A 64-bit multiplicative hash encoding the full solver state enables $O(1)$ average-case lookups – the entire DP solver's efficiency hinges on this single design decision.
- Separating the solver thread from the Swing EDT is not merely a UI nicety but a structural necessity for any interactive application embedding a computationally intensive algorithm.

Future Directions

- **Hybrid solver:** switch from backtracking to DP automatically when n exceeds a calibrated threshold.
- **Bidirectional DP:** expand layers from both A and B simultaneously, meeting in the middle to halve the effective budget.
- **Profile-guided constraint ordering:** prioritise rows and columns with the tightest remaining slack for both pruning checks.

- **Sparse state representation:** delta-encode `rowUsed`/`colUsed` arrays to reduce memory per state and enable $n \geq 15$.

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END OF REPORT